

ASHA JADEJA
Founder, Motwani Jadeja Foundation

TARANJIT SINGH SANDHU
Former Indian Ambassador to the US

AIR CHIEF MARSHAL R.K.S. BHADAURIA (RETD)
Former Chief of Air staff

RAJ CHENGAPPA
Group Editorial Director, India Today Group

GOING BEYOND COMFORT ZONES

The Indo-Pacific region is where the next great game for supremacy is being played out, with China trying to impose hegemonic control over the region through its economic, military, diplomatic and technological might. Now, other powers have recognised India as a pivotal balancing power here. This presents India with threats and opportunities. On this premise, army chief Gen. Manoj Pande said that India must be wary of the threats that emanate from the rivalry of China and the US and their differing world-views. India must see that this doesn't spiral into conflict, and the world expects India to play that role. Other threats emerge from regional rivalries, terrorism, cross-border trafficking and cyber threats. With much of the world's economic activity centred on the Indo-Pacific, India, with its thriving economy and demographic dividend can regard this as a "theatre of opportunity", felt Gen. Pande. India can "leverage its position" through strategic engagements like the Indo-Pacific Army Chiefs Conference (held in Delhi in September 2023), through multilateral bodies (like the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative), through humanitarian assistance and through greater maritime domain awareness and a pro-active role by the navy. The situation along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) with China is "stable but sensitive", the army is keeping a close watch and India's deployment of troops and equipment is "extremely robust", said Gen. Pande. To enhance capabilities, India was building infrastructure like roads till the LAC, adapting technology like better surveillance and precision targeting and better communication (5G). Laying emphasis on the threat of non-kinetic warfare, Gen. Pande said India was speedily adopting the fusion of niche technologies (AI, Quantum, Internet of Things, Machine Learning, cyber surveillance), and tying up with indigenous start-ups to develop

Photograph by HARDIK CHHABRA